

Tadao Ando

From his earliest designs, the self-taught minimalist Japanese architect Tadao Ando (b.1941) demonstrated his grasp of the traditional *sukiya* style, with its use of natural materials, balanced proportions and serene ambiance – such as in his tiny Azuma House (1976) in Osaka, connected by an open air bridge, or the Matsumoto House in Ashiya (1976–7), also known as the Wall House, with its concrete frame spanned by half-tunnel vaulting. Ando has continued to design public and commercial complexes with the same traditional spirit and his own perceptions of minimalism and nature. Often using concrete or natural wood, his style is said to create a ‘haiku’ effect, emphasizing empty space and simplicity, while also melding with the environment. His Church on the Water (1988) in Tomamu, the Literature Museum (1989, opposite) in Himeji and the Water Temple (1991) on Awaji Island, for instance, all use sheets of water in imaginative ways. Convinced that architecture can change cities and reform society, Ando has been influential through his constantly evolving designs and prolific writing.

